Johannes Tauler — The Sermons

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the six subject reviewers named in the index are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Johannes Tauler of Strasbourg, Dominican and pupil of Meister Eckhart, remembered in this record as the most pastoral voice of the Rhineland mystics. His sermons are among the monuments of the German language, and Luther praised him above nearly all medieval writers, so his voice carried far beyond his own century and his own city. Yet, apart from Walter Elliott's complete English of the attributed corpus, published in 1910, English readers have met the sermons in partial gatherings: selections of twenty-five sermons, thirty-six festival sermons, and other selections and excerpts spread across more than a century. What this record did not find, after research, is a complete English translation of the authentic sermons from Vetter's critical German text. This presentation is dedicated to the preacher Strasbourg loved, in the hope that English readers may one day hear that authentic voice whole, sermon by sermon, in the order of the church year.

The story

Johannes Tauler (c. 1300–1361) was a Strasbourg Dominican, a pupil of Meister Eckhart, and the most pastoral voice of the Rhineland mystics. Luther praised him above nearly all medieval writers, and his sermons are among the monuments of the German language.

For English readers, that voice has arrived in fragments for more than a century and a half. One old edition contains 153 sermons under his name; the oldest manuscript authority supports far fewer. Scholarship's own summary verdict, recorded in this research, is that a good English translation of Tauler's sermons is lacking, and the record below bears that out. A second-pass check in October 2026 then corrected the framing in an important way: a broad claim that no complete English Tauler existed was falsified by a 1910 volume, while a narrower claim — about the authentic sermons, translated from the critical German text — was cleared. Both halves of that correction are given below.

The work and what survives

On the oldest manuscript authority — two near-contemporary Strasbourg manuscripts — 84 sermons rest, and the Leipzig printing of 1498 has exactly these 84. Later printings swell the count: the Frankfurt edition of 1826 that Susanna Winkworth used contains 153, including pieces gathered under his name afterwards. Ferdinand Vetter's *Die Predigten Taulers* (Berlin: Weidmann, 1910) is the standard scholarly German text; it is in the public domain and was reprinted in 1968. The material is public domain throughout: a fourteenth-century author and a 1910 edition.

A reviewer's check adds precision on counts. Vetter's critical edition rests on 81 sermons; the Leipzig 1498 printing has 84; and the Frankfurt and Hamberger attributed corpus runs to 145 — Parts I–II *de tempore*, the sermons for the seasons of the church year, with Part III comprising 37 festal sermons. Choosing a base text, Vetter's authenticity against Frankfurt completeness, is a build-time ruling for the author of this collection.

Its English fortunes

Susanna Winkworth (1857) translated 25 sermons, a public-domain English selection — about 30 percent of the corpus on this dossier's own figures of 81–84 sermons; no comparative check for "best" is stated. Arthur Wollaston Hutton's *The Inner Way* (1901) gives 36 festival sermons, also public domain. Eric Colledge and Sister Mary Jane (1961) offer loose renderings and excerpts, rearranged by theme, and are in copyright. Maria Shrady (Paulist Press, 1985) gives 23 sermons, translated not from the Middle High German but from Hofmann's modern German, and is in copyright. Complete translations exist in French (Hugueny, Théry, and Corin, 1927–35) and Dutch (Freens, 2015); English is the

laggard language. Only 3 of Hutton's sermons overlap Winkworth, so public-domain English totals about 58 distinct sermons across two partial volumes a century apart.

Hutton also left a promise in print. His 1901 introduction states his plan plainly: if the Festal volume succeeded, the *de tempore* sermons "may follow in two or three volumes." No Hutton sequel was found after research. But that must not be read as meaning no complete English cycle ever appeared.

Walter Elliott's *The Sermons and Conferences of John Tauler* (Washington, D.C.: Apostolic Mission House, 1910; Internet Archive `sermonsconferenc00taul`) is a complete-in-scope English Tauler. Its title page reads "First Complete English Translation," and its contents run the full liturgical year, from Advent to the 23rd Sunday after Trinity — a complete *de tempore* — plus a *de sanctis* series. Elliott's stated source is Bamberger's modernised German edition (Frankfurt, 1864), the expanded attributed corpus, with Sainte-Foi's French and Surius's Latin consulted, and an interpretive rendering openly acknowledged. So an English *de tempore* cycle has existed since 1910.

What survives the check, cleared on an Internet Archive census, the OpenLibrary graph, OpenAlex dissertations, and the scholarly editions survey, is narrower and exact: **no English translation of the authentic sermon corpus from Vetter's critical Middle High German text — complete, or of its *de tempore* portion as a critically based cycle — found after research.** The licensed pitch for any new edition is "first English translation of the authentic sermons from Vetter's critical text," with Elliott 1910 named and credited in the front matter as the prior complete English of the attributed corpus. If the base-text ruling goes to Frankfurt completeness instead, the project becomes an honestly labelled re-translation, not a first.

What completing it would take

Completing the work would mean a fresh translation from Vetter's Middle High German, sermon by sermon in liturgical order — Advent, the Christmas cycle, Lent, and the festival sermons forming natural instalments. Winkworth and Hutton serve as public-domain check-texts where they overlap; the remaining sermons have no English rendering from Vetter's text. The review standard set for it is a Middle High German reader together with a Dominican or mystical-theology reader.

Sources

- https://ccel.org/ccel/winkworth/tauler/tauler.iv.html (Winkworth's own introduction: the 153-sermon Frankfurt edition vs the 84 of manuscript authority)
- http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Johannes_Tauler (editions and translations survey; the "lacking" verdict; French/Dutch completeness)
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- https://catalog.hathitrust.org/Record/008413383 (the 1888 Boston abridgement of Winkworth)
- https://ccel.org/ccel/t/tauler/inner_way/cache/inner_way.pdf
- https://www.studylight.org/encyclopedias/eng/tce/j/john-tauler.html